boys' network', i.e. the informal network of the business, political and even cultural elite from the Communist era which continued to hold power. To finance a (crooked) management buyout, a manager, probably a former party apparatchik, would have a far better chance of getting a loan with a bank than a 'stranger'. Such practices were also facilitated by the weak and dispersed ownership that could not exercise proper control of the management. For their part, the former political elite often made sure that legislation provided a sufficiently vague legal environment to shield their friends in the business elite from potential domestic and foreign competitors. Often the politically attractive argument of 'national interest' was used to support the creation of such legislation. All this, of course, came at the price of financing the now-reformed parties' political machinery that would return them to power every four years and thus help replicate the political elite. A survey of the various elites in the country, carried out in post-Communist Slovenia in 1995, has shown that the people who constituted the economic and cultural/artistic elite in that year were 89% the same as they were in 1988 before the changes. Only within the political elite was the equivalent figure lower – at 71%.[100] The case was much the same in Hungary and, to some extent, in Poland, although in the Czech Republic the former elite lost almost all of the little credibility and legitimacy it once possessed. Two decades later, there is a growing number of the conservative electorate in Eastern Europe that believes this replication of elites is alive and well.

In many societies in transition it took years before canny apparatchiks accepted normal ways of doing business and discovered that a good corporate culture is better – even for them – than murky business practices. (In the meantime, those playing by the rules suffered grave disadvantages.) Gradually, businessmen and politicians during the transition years came to look like responsible and respectable citizens, even in the eyes of foreign analysts and business partners, who might embody the virtues of stability, predictability and the right yields.

But, for those who were looked down on during the Communist years, seeing the same people in power again has been simply too much to bear. It has created frustration, augmented support for unconventional, often chauvinist, political parties and fuelled the kind of radical conservative emotions that put off foreign observers and analysts so much, and